Integrating Mindful Movement

with Teja Fudo Myoo Bell

FLOWING MINDFULNESS THROUGH THE FIVE FIELDS OF THE BODY

This is a grounding and centering practice that helps to establish mindfulness in and through the whole body in a graduated and sequential flow of attention.
This practice comes from the internal arts practice of Taijiquan (Tie / Chee / Chawn).
The Five Fields of the body are:

1. Feet and ankles
2. Legs (lower legs, knees, and upper legs)
3. Hips and pelvis
4. Torso including arms
5. Neck and head

Guidance for Leading This Practice

- Establish the intention for awareness and presence that gradually opens through the entire body
- Grounding into and through the feet-earth connection in feeling and settled-ness
- Encourage "eyes open and soft gaze"
- Support natural and normal awareness
- The process is one of gentleness and "feeling" connected in spontaneous movement that begins in the feet and ankles and continues to move, connecting the entire body with natural awareness, aliveness, and grounded presence throughout the interconnected system of our embodiment
- Moving through each Field can be anywhere from 15 to 90 seconds in length. Not hurrying awareness, but allowing a flow of connected feeling to be present and embodied.
- Completing the connected flow of mindfulness through the Five Fields, encourage a smooth and seamless transition into the standing meditation gesture

You can use phrases such as: "Begin with the feeling of settling downward and connecting with the earth energetically. Let the body and mind relax into these normal and ordinary feelings and sensations that we often take for granted. Relax and move with ease and comfort. Allow the sensations that become present in this flow to be there exactly as they are—changing moment by moment as they do. Everything comes alive with calm and integrated mindful presence."

STANDING MEDITATION GESTURE

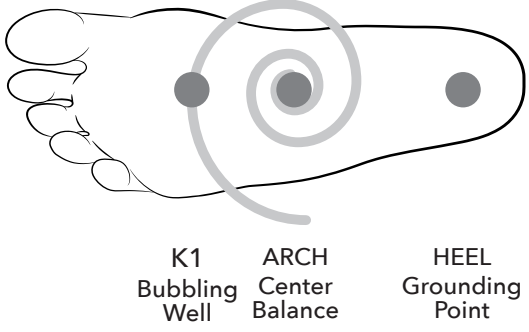
Standing meditation is one of the four primary gestures for applying mindfulness as embodied presence:

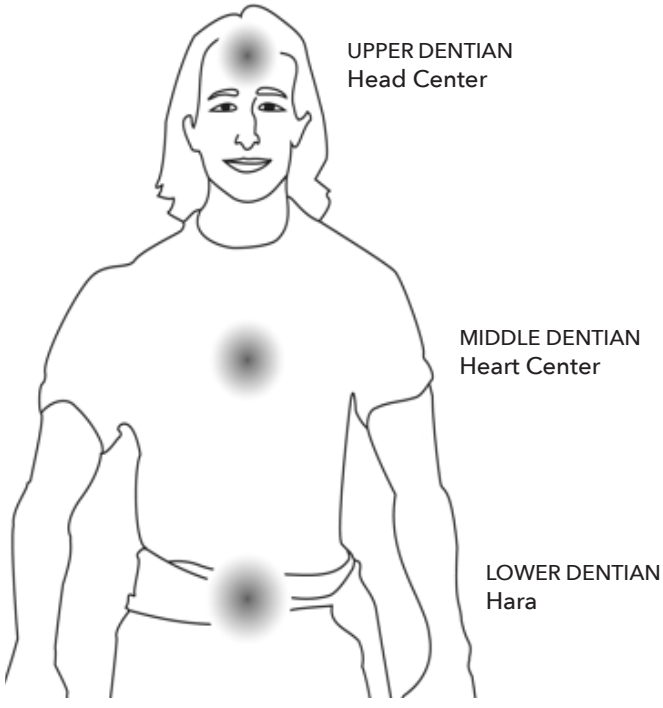
1. Seated forms
2. Standing forms
3. Moving forms (walking / qigong / yoga)
4. Lying-down forms

Standing meditation instructions contain the essential elements for postural integrity and alignment for success in meditation and mindfulness.

Please review and consider these guidelines in your own posture and alignment for embodied meditation practice before assisting and guiding others. It is so important to make sure that you have some command of these elements in your own practice first. Take this instruction as a gradual unfoldment of embodiment of your own mindfulness. Be patient and kind with yourself and with everyone you have the privilege to guide.

1. Feet about shoulder width, parallel—feeling: stable
2. Knees slightly bent, hips relaxed—feeling: settled
3. All the joints are relaxed, not locked—feeling: spacious
4. Effortless vertical alignment of the three centers along energetic centerline
5. Whole body dynamically relaxed; standing with integrity and minimum effort
6. Weight is naturally grounded through feet
7. Spine is open with the sense of length
8. Back of neck relaxes and head gently and naturally opens upwards
9. Natural abdominal breathing—releasing tension
10. Eyes "soft" and peaceful (not fixed)
11. Tongue naturally rests in mouth lightly touching upper palate
12. Mind relaxes in "field awareness" of the physical and energetic bodies





Guidance for Leading This Practice

- Practice this first to establish all the elements in your own system before guiding others. There is no "perfect" here, but you are encouraged to directly know each of these qualities as you lead others.
- Be able to internally connect with each "element" of practice to guide yourself and then others.
- Be patient and kind. Make haste slowly.
- Standing meditation can be done with eyes open (soft gaze) or eyes closed. If there are any issues of balance or compromised proprioception, use eyes open and a soft gaze.
- Relatively short periods of practice are advised in beginning this practice. Specifically, no more than three to five minutes to start. Individuals may sit down at any time.
- Standing meditation is not something to do only when you are tired of sitting. It is a legitimate and widely used gesture of meditation and has many benefits that must be experienced to be fully appreciated.
- Modifications:
  - Hands rest at the side of the body, but do not press arms directly on the side of the body. Open the lateral channels of the body by facing the back of the hands forward to create a little space under the arms.
    - Note: This takes some practice and learning the skill of releasing tension of holding the muscles with strength and effort to letting go to ease and softness
  - Hands may also rest—one over the other—below the navel area, the hara
- There is no specific script to guide standing meditation. My advice is to practice in front of a mirror and as you do so give yourself the guidance as you connect with the felt-sense of the elements.
- When this is well established in your own practice, you will be able to effectively and naturally give authentic guidance in standing meditation.

RADIANT BODY BREATHING

Whole Body Breathing From standing meditation posture, arms slowly open upward from the sides with the inhalation. Palms face downward until shoulder height, and then turn palms upward, lifting overhead, continuing inhalation. Begin exhalation as palms face toward the body flowing downward along left and right channels. Bend knees and lower hips slightly while exhaling; straighten body while inhaling. Feel the smoothing and soothing quality of the movement.

Central Channel Breathing Begin with hands in front of the hara. With fingertips pointing downward and palms facing inward toward the body. Slowing inhale while flowing the hands upward along centerline. The qi moves upward along the central channel and fountains out the crown of the head. Release the hands so the palms face outward, lowering them out and away from the body with the exhalation. Continue this circulation movement—slowing softly and continuously. Each breath relaxes, releases, and vitalizes. Stay present to the actual experience.

Guidance for Leading This Practice

- The forms of Radiant Body Breathing are simple in structure but wonderfully profound in results. Five to ten repetitions are sufficient for meditation and grounding.
- Return to standing meditation in mindful presence after each set, 15 to 30 seconds.

- Feel the sensations that arise, are present, and pass.
- Encourage natural and normal awareness.

You can use phrases such as: "Let the whole body breathe. Let go of any sense of hurry or accomplishment with this practice. Stay in feeling. Let the results of your practice naturally unfold."

PULSING FROM THE CORE

This practice is an energetic and systemic *natural release* and reset for the central nervous system. The "core" in this case is the whole length of the spine and the nervous system into the brain. The "pulse" is a *kind* and *gentle action* of wrapping the torso forward and backward while settling the lower spine downward and gently lifting the head upward in a smooth and continuous fluid motion. Don't worry, it's a lot easier and intuitive in action than in the description.

This is a very easy and effective practice for healing and nourishing the brain and nervous system and bringing the autonomic nervous into balance and harmony. Thus it is a natural stress reliever. As a practice of mindfulness, it focuses on the principles of *connecting with feeling* through the body, *moving with ease, under-doing the effort* and range of motion and the *70 percent principle*. Use this written description to connect with the practice after you have learned and practiced it with me.

- Begin with the back of the hands facing each other in front of the hara. Allow the spine to relax into a bow or C-shape. No strain, no stress, and no pain. Insist on these guidelines if and when you lead this practice. They are essential to the effectiveness of the practice.
- Settle the hips downward and let the lower lumbar area relax and expand. From the rounded shape, begin the in-breath with lifting the shoulders upward and slowly rolling up and back and then downward with the hands along the sides of the body with the exhale.
- Complete this cycle with the back of the hands meeting again in front of the hara. Continue seamlessly. Note that this action creates an elliptical shape.
- Relax into this fluid movement.
- Connect with the value of under-doing the effort and range of motion needed.
- Complete the first cycle of repetitions (five to nine) by returning to the standing meditation posture for a few moments before reversing the pattern to balance the energy and complete the practice. This is a great mindfulness opportunity.
- From stillness, reverse the pattern by opening the heart and chest by moving the shoulder blades inward toward the spine in the back. From this opening, lift and rotate shoulders upward, then circulate forward and downward until the back of the hands face each other once again in the front of the body. In this action you lower the hands and hips, and bend the knees. At the bottom of the cycle, the palms face the ground and glide backward past the hips to begin the elliptical cycle again.
- Move slowing and mindfully, gradually letting go into greater ease and softness by under-doing the range of motion while staying present to the pulse.

Guidance for Leading This Practice

- Pulsing from the Core can be a very effective mindfulness, settling and healing practice to engage with your students or clients.
- *The form of the practice is the gateway to the practice of the principle:* Learning how to directly connect with ease, to feel the *whole body move in unity* with gentleness, and to safely and

naturally feel direct connection to the autonomic nervous system in balance is a great gift and kindness to ourselves and others.

- To learn and guide this practice, I advise to once again practice in front of the mirror and gradually offer yourself the verbal instructions that are connected with the form and the principles of integrating mindful movement. When you can do this without any visual reference to the page, you will be ready to genuinely guide others.

SETTLING IN THE HARA AND BALANCING IN THE HEART

This is a wonderful way of completing any embodied mindfulness session.

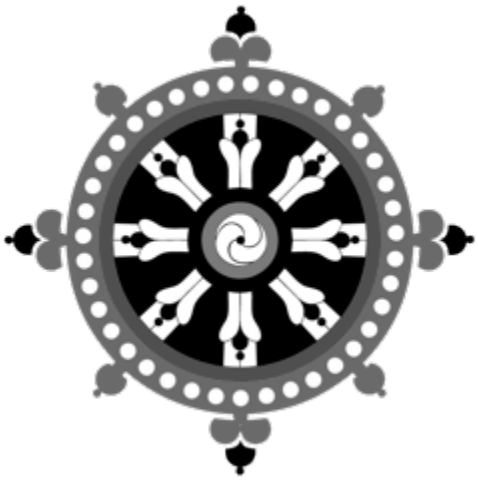
To Settle in the Hara, simply bring your hands one over another directly below the navel area and rest your hands there, making direct contact with the front part of this lower abdominal area. Allow the sense of settling down the energy of the body into this field of nurturing presence. No special thought is needed to release downward with trust in the goodness of life and the intelligence of body, which is also the goodness and intelligence of the Universe in you. Rest there and conserve your qi in this field of being. Thirty to sixty seconds is sufficient. You can always practice longer on your own.

Complete your practice with the ancient gesture of Balancing in the Heart.

The fingertips touch as palms come together in from of the sternum.

Bring feet together. Rest in Meditation. Feeling balance.

Connect with your Heart's intention for health and well-being and extend that primal goodness in the spirit of generosity to all life—to our planet, to all worlds—through time and space. This is the presence and integration of our true nature in practice and direct knowing/being.



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